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LIBRARY LESSON PLAN

Seeing Through Deception

Grades 6–8 · Library · Advanced Information Literacy

Students develop sophisticated source evaluation skills by connecting the history of visual deception — from spirit photography to deepfakes — to contemporary information literacy challenges.

THE 35 MINUTES

5 min	10 min	5 min	12 min	3 min
HOOK	THE SIFT METHOD	PSYCHOLOGY OF BELIEF	SIFT IN ACTION	CLOSING

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Students will trace the evolution of visual misinformation from 1860s spirit photography to modern deepfakes, master the SIFT method for lateral reading and source verification, and apply these skills to evaluate real-world examples.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

- **AASL I.B.1:** Using evidence to investigate questions.
- **AASL I.D.2:** Evaluating information for accuracy, validity, context.
- **CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.RI.7.8:** Trace and evaluate the argument and specific claims in a text.

MATERIALS NEEDED

Spirit photography examples from Mini Museum · Modern manipulated images · Brief deepfake video clip · SIFT method poster/handout · Sample sources for lateral reading practice

Mini Museum Perception Lab:
minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving/illusions

RECOMMENDED RESOURCES

- *True or False? A CIA Analyst's Guide* by Cindy L. Otis
- *Verified: How to Think Straight* by Caulfield & Wineburg

LESSON PLAN · HOOK: A 160-YEAR TIMELINE OF DECEPTION · 5 MINUTES

Display timeline: Spirit Photography (1860s) → Photo Retouching (1900s) → Photoshop (1990s) → Deepfakes (2010s–present).

"Every generation faces a new form of visual deception — and every generation thinks THEY can spot the fakes. In the 1860s, thousands paid money for photographs of ghosts they believed were real. They weren't stupid — they were trusting. Photography was new technology, and they didn't know it could be manipulated. WE are in exactly the same position today with AI-generated content."

THE SIFT METHOD: PROFESSIONAL VERIFICATION · 10 MINUTES

Introduce the SIFT method, developed by digital literacy expert Mike Caulfield:

S STOP

Before you share, react, or use the information — pause. Don't let emotion drive action.

I INVESTIGATE the source

What do you know about this website, author, or organization? Take 30 seconds to find out WHO is behind the content.

F FIND better coverage

Can you find the same claim elsewhere? Check if reputable sources cover this story.

T TRACE to the original

Where did this information ACTUALLY come from? Follow the chain to the primary source.

"This is what professional fact-checkers do. The key insight is LATERAL READING — instead of reading deeply on a suspicious site, you leave it immediately and search for information ABOUT that source."

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION: THE PSYCHOLOGY OF BELIEF · 5 MINUTES

Reference the exhibition. William Mumler was put on trial for fraud in 1869 but acquitted — not because innocent, but because prosecution couldn't prove HOW he faked photos.

- **Why were grieving families especially vulnerable?** (Emotional state, motivated reasoning)
- **How does this connect to modern misinformation?** (We believe what we WANT to believe)
- **What would have helped Victorians verify?** (Consulting experts, comparing work — lateral reading)

ACTIVITY: SIFT IN ACTION · 12 MINUTES

Present 3–4 examples of varying reliability:

- A viral social media post claiming a celebrity said something shocking (no source link)
- A Wikipedia article on a scientific topic
- A news story from an unfamiliar website
- A spirit photograph from 1870 (historical application)

For each: **S** (What's your emotional reaction?), **I** (What can you find about this source?), **F** (Who else covers this?), **T** (Can you trace to primary source?)

CLOSING: YOUR RESPONSIBILITY · 3 MINUTES

"You are growing up in the first generation where anyone can create convincing fake video and audio. These skills work across ALL media. Lateral reading, source checking, and emotional awareness will never become obsolete."

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit: The exhibition provides a perfect case study for visual deception exploiting psychological vulnerabilities. Spirit photography targeted grief; deepfakes target political division.

Option 2 — Virtual: Explore the exhibition online.

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving

DIFFERENTIATED STUDENT HANDOUTS

GREEN LEVEL
MORE SUPPORT

SIFT reference guide with scaffolded source evaluation.

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

Independent SIFT analysis of multiple sources with explanation.

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Research project on deepfakes; create verification guide for peers.

ASSESSMENT

- **Application:** Can students correctly apply all four SIFT steps to a novel source?
- **Analysis:** Can students explain WHY lateral reading works better than reading deeply on a suspicious site?
- **Exit ticket:** *"Explain the connection between spirit photography and modern misinformation."*